onto a dirt track, driving up a narrow, steep passage. At the top, a small town stood on the hill overlooking the valley below. Léa stared at the church and castle as they passed them in the square, everything painted pale white and blue. Then the car went down the other side, an expanse of green fields and forests as far as the eye could see.

Crack! The car jolted to a stop. Léa, thrown against the back of the driver's seat, clutched Katya to her chest as they both fell into the footwell. Her forehead burned; something warm and thick trickled down the side of her head.

"Léa—" Josef called out.

Crack! Crack!

Josef crumpled down, blood deep ruby red all over the seat. Léa screamed. André reached for his gun, but another bullet shot a hole in his neck, and he collapsed on the footwell next to her. A sea of blood. *Josef? André?* She could still see them as they'd been seconds before. They were going to cross together to the other side of the Elbe, where it was safe. Clutching Katya close to her heart, Léa's senses were heightened—everything came at her in fragments, shattered by fear and blood.

"There's a woman," a man called out in German with a heavy foreign accent. He stood outside the car, hovering over Josef, pointing his Karabiner in the air.

"Are you German?" he said.

"I . . . am French." A viselike grip squeezed her throat.

"We want the car. Get out."

She struggled to draw in air. *Josef, please stand.* We'll go now. She wanted to touch him, but feared the man would shoot her if she tried. Josef's head twisted at an unnatural angle. His hands, palms facing the sky, speckled with blood. Léa started to cry.

"Shut up." The man lowered the Karabiner. "Get out or I will shoot you and the baby."

Trembling, she took the bag, climbed out of the car and stumbled onto her knees. Other men were making their way through the grass toward her. She stood, legs wobbly and unstable. *Walk.* She was numb. The world had gone black. Holding on tight to Katya, Léa ran into the woods.

Her arms throbbed, but she couldn't stop. In her mind, she kept seeing the man with the Karabiner glaring down at her, holding her in his sights.